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The three CBE pathways, explained

A plain-language guide for learners and parents

From Grade 10, every learner in Kenya's Senior School chooses one of three pathways. The choice shapes the subjects they study and the options they have after Grade 12, and switching later is genuinely difficult. Use this guide to talk it through before pathway selection at the end of Grade 9.

STEM

Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics

Suits learners who are strong in the sciences and mathematics.

May lead toward medicine, engineering, technology, data science and related fields.

Typical electives: Biology, Chemistry, Physics, Computer Science, Agriculture and technical or applied science options.

Social Sciences

People, society, language, business

Suits learners who are drawn to understanding people, society and governance.

May lead toward law, business, education, governance and community leadership.

Typical electives: literature, history and citizenship, geography, business studies, and foreign or indigenous languages.

Arts and Sports Science

Creativity, performance, physical talent

Suits learners who are built around creativity, performance and sporting talent.

May lead toward creative industries, media, and professional or academic sports.

Typical electives: music, dance, theatre, visual and fine arts, sports and recreation.

Good to know

- Every learner takes core subjects, including English, Kiswahili and Mathematics, whatever the pathway.
- Pathway selection is guided by KJSEA results, interests and career goals.
- Not every school offers every pathway, so the decision can also involve which school a learner attends.
- A learner who starts in one pathway and later wants another may miss a year of key subjects.

Choosing well, not just quickly

The learners who do best are usually those who have had an honest, unhurried conversation about what they are good at, what they enjoy and what each pathway demands day to day. Book a guidance session with ECCO to have that conversation with a trained guidance officer.

Based on ECCO's article "Understanding the three CBE pathways". Details can change: confirm with your school and the Ministry of Education. Information as of November 2026.